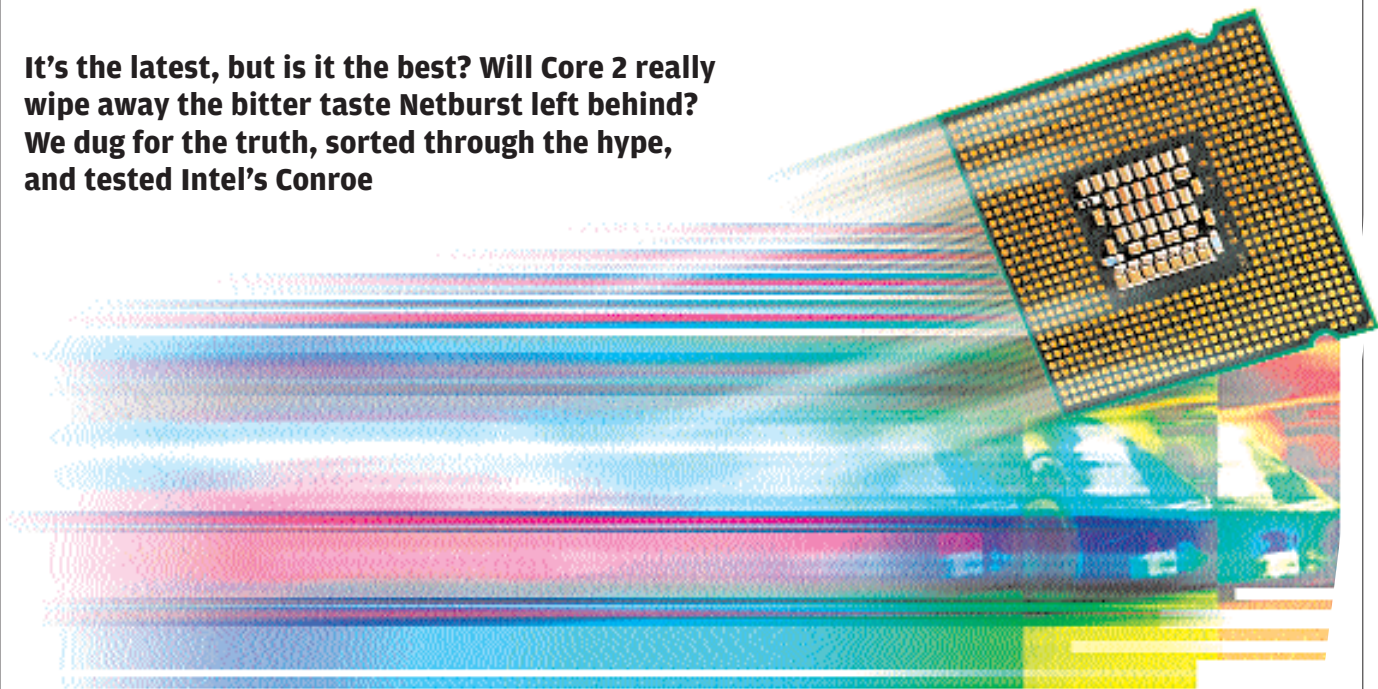


Here Comes AMD's Nemesis!

It's the latest, but is it the best? Will Core 2 really wipe away the bitter taste Netburst left behind? We dug for the truth, sorted through the hype, and tested Intel's Conroe



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With Intel's Core 2 Duo having been officially released, it's time to put all the rumours floating around to rest—rumours of how Core 2 Duo a.k.a. Conroe, leaves even AM2 processors chewing the dust, while consuming less power. More for less? We're a sceptical lot at *Digit*, and are not given to believing rumours concerning anything in the PC realm until we get down and dirty with it ourselves. Seeing is, after all, believing; and we just *had* to see this!

Having just gotten our greedy paws on (and off) the AM2 5000+, we were somewhat dissatisfied. Performance was at best, just a tad ahead of what 939 AMD64 dual cores delivered. The switchover to a new platform didn't affect much of anything as far as the AMD corner goes.

Imagine our excitement when we received a shiny new Conroe—the X6800, no less—and

its faithful compatriot, the Intel 975XBX. The X6800 is a 2.93 GHz Extreme Edition; in layman's terms, it's *Top Of The Line!* The Intel 975XBX is, of course, somewhat a known identity: the board has been around for some months now.

Combination, Innovation, Redefinition

Intel had some serious thermal issues with their Netburst architecture, and this pervaded right through their dual-core series as well. AMD was relatively well-off:

their Athlon 64s performed better per clock, and ran much cooler in the bargain. Prescotts were termed “mini nuclear reactors” for the amount of power they consumed, while AMD 64s and the X2 dual-cores were a runaway success in 90 per cent of the benchmarks we used.

Conroe represents not just a change in architecture but a redesign from scratch. The Conroe incorporates the best elements of the Netburst architecture, and combines the winning features of Intel's Pentium M and

